The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AARON SCHWARTZ/POOL/EPA/Shutterstock

Donald Trump asked China to put back a meeting with **Xi Jinping** "by a month or so". Mr Trump said he wanted a postponement because the war in Iran required him to stay in Washington. "There's no tricks" to the request, he said. Mr Trump had previously suggested the summit, which was originally scheduled to begin on March 31st, would be delayed unless China helped America to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

America's president also denounced allies who refused his request for assistance in reopening the strait. **Germany, Italy** and **Spain** have ruled out participating in military missions; **Australia**, **France** and **Japan** do not intend to send warships. **Britain's** prime minister said he was pursuing a "viable plan" but would not be "drawn into the wider war". Separately, a drone struck America's embassy in Baghdad, **Iraq's** capital.

Australia's central bank raised **interest rates** for a second consecutive month, to 4.1%. It said that was "in response to the expected inflationary implications of the conflict in the Middle East". The Bank of England, the Federal Reserve, the European Central Bank and the Bank of Japan are expected to hold rates this week.

Afghanistan blamed **Pakistan** for an air strike on a hospital which it said had killed 400 people “so far”. Pakistan called accusations that it was behind the attack “baseless”, adding that it had “precisely” targeted military and terrorist facilities. The two countries have been skirmishing for months, with Pakistan accusing Afghanistan’s Taliban rulers of harbouring terrorists.

Mr Trump said he believed he would have “the honour” of taking **Cuba**, and that “I could do anything I want with it”. The president’s bravado came as the island’s electricity grid collapsed in the face of America’s attempt to cut off fuel imports. Around 10m Cubans are without power. The island has suffered several outages in recent months; last week violent protests broke out in response to the blackouts.

At least 23 people were killed and 108 injured in two suspected suicide bombings in Maiduguri, the capital of Borno state in north-east **Nigeria**. For 17 years the state has stood at the centre of an insurgency by Boko Haram, an Islamist outfit trying to establish a caliphate, which has displaced 2m people and killed thousands. Jihadists have also branched out to Nigeria’s north-west.

Scientists may have discovered a new type of **planet**. Unlike other rocky or watery worlds, L 98-59 d, as it is known, contains “an ocean of magma” and a sulphurous atmosphere. Researchers used telescopes and computer simulations to map the formation of the molten planet, which is located roughly 35 light years from Earth. They said its conditions are unlikely to support life.

Figure of the day: 45%, the share of household waste in Britain that is recycled, up from 5% in 1996. Read our story on how industrial-scale fly-tipping, which is spreading across Britain, undermines that progress.

Photograph: Reuters

Is Israel ready for a long war?

Over the weekend Semafor, a news site, reported that Israel's stocks of ballistic-missile interceptors may be "running critically low". The claim drew fierce denials from Israeli officials, who insisted the country was prepared for "prolonged combat".

But its supplies are surely being tested: Iran, which was thought to have around 2,500 ballistic missiles at the start of the war, has already launched hundreds. Our analysis suggests Gulf states—which say they have taken out some 800 Iranian missiles and 2,500 drones—are burning through their interceptor stocks. And Iran is insisting more attacks are coming: on Monday it repeated threats that it would start targeting American companies in the Gulf soon. The precise number of remaining interceptors and missiles on each side remains a closely guarded secret. The war's length could be determined in part by whose stocks hold out longest.

Photograph: AP

Britain’s chancellor’s pitch for growth

Rachel Reeves will set out her vision for Britain’s economy on Tuesday in a speech. Official forecasters expect the economy to grow by just 1.1% in 2026. As Labour languishes in the polls, the chancellor will try to reassure sceptics that she has a credible plan.

Her speech is expected to cover three themes. First, Labour says it wants closer ties with Europe, but has ruled out any changes that might make a serious difference, including rejoining the customs union. Second, Ms Reeves will elaborate on how Britain can become a leader in artificial intelligence; Britain has a compelling pitch on safety but has struggled to find its footing in an arena dominated by America and China. And finally, Ms Reeves wants to redistribute growth between the regions. But volatile oil and gas prices, thanks to the war in the Middle East, will do more to shape Labour’s political future than anything the chancellor can muster in her speech.

Photograph: Getty Images

Havana’s Hail Mary

America’s Cuban exiles will soon be allowed to invest in the private sector, own property and start their own businesses in their motherland for the first time in decades. Cuba’s deputy prime minister, Oscar Pérez-Oliva Fraga, is expected to announce a new “fluid commercial relationship” with American companies and the Cuban-American community in the coming days. The decision is a desperate pivot. Venezuela had been a primary source of subsidised oil for Cuba. That changed overnight when America kidnapped Venezuela’s leader, Nicolás Maduro, and then blocked oil shipments to the island, exacerbating its energy crisis.

On Friday Cuba admitted that it had started talks with the Trump administration, which has warned that the island’s government “is going to fall pretty soon” unless it makes a deal. For now, America’s six-decade-old embargo prohibits investment in Cuba. Cubans in America, who have long supported America’s sanctions in the hope that they may accelerate regime change, may now find their loyalties split.

Photograph: Getty Images

The Irish example for minority languages everywhere

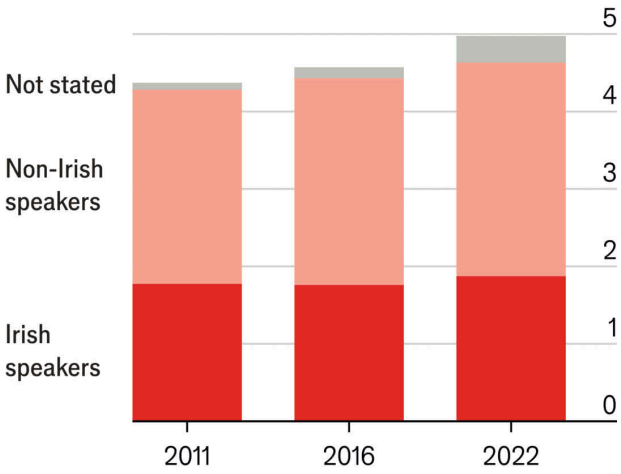
Tuesday is St Patrick's Day, and Ireland has much to celebrate. Its ancient language is experiencing a remarkable revival. A century ago just 18% of Ireland's population spoke Irish; UNESCO has declared it "definitely endangered". Today roughly 40% of Ireland's population (some 1.9m people) speak Irish—a 71% increase from 1991.

The shift reflects something difficult to measure: Irish has become cool. Irish actors such as Cillian Murphy and Paul Mescal have spoken Irish on the world stage, while Kneecap, an Irish-language hip-hop group, has earned global recognition. Irish-speaking social-media influencers have made the language a fixture of everyday life.

State policy has helped, too. The government has set a 20% recruitment quota for Irish speakers in the public sector by 2030; Irish has been an official working language in the European Union since 2022. Being an English-speaking country in the bloc has helped Ireland prosper. But Irish makes it Irish, even if few people speak it daily.

The state of Irish

Ireland, population aged 3 and over, m



Source: Central Statistics Office

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: The Bellman is a key character in which Lewis Carroll poem?

Monday: Which character is portrayed by Sigourney Weaver in the Alien films?

No society can surely be flourishing and happy, of which the far greater part of the members are poor and miserable.

Adam Smith